eyes that if they sent me overseas, I'd shoot a general. The other doctor said, "Yes, and you'd miss him." My report read: "Confined to the continental limits, eligible for corps area service command or War Department overhead only." So I was a liaison officer. All of us newcomers were cavalry. Then we discovered the commanding general of Fort Mason was a cavalry officer.

My career in loading ships only lasted a few months, then Colonel Booker called me in and showed me an order transferring me to Army Air Force Intelligence, Los Angeles, California.

At the time, General Hap Arnold was moving toward achieving his dream of creating an independent air force. He'd established the intelligence unit to make air force training films and documentaries, train camera crews, and accompany our planes on combat missions. I was sent to the unit because of my experience in motion pictures.

My first assignment was to recruit technicians and artists from the movie business for the new unit who were ineligible for the draft, and pretty soon, even though I was wearing the bars of a second lieutenant, I was offering majors' insignias to half-million-dollar-a-year movie directors. We also had first call on draftees from the industry.

Our unit took over the Hal Roach film studio in Culver City and a nearby, recently closed school that became our training center for combat camera crews. Before long, the post was being called "Fort Roach"—a completely unofficial title and one, I think, that was not intended to be complimentary.

I wound up as adjutant and personnel officer for the unit. Our combat camera crews went to every war zone in the world and our training films were used throughout the army air corps. In a way, we'd become the Signal Corps for Hap Arnold's new air force.